BONUS 02

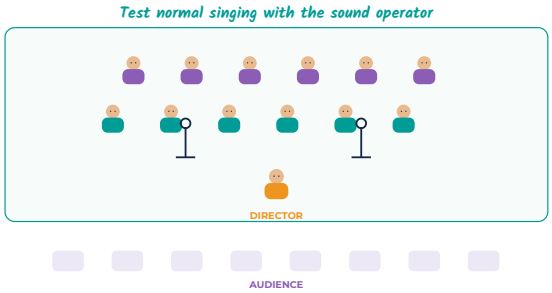
STAGE-READY CHOIR

A practical guide to programme planning, cues, scores, soundcheck, backstage preparation, and calm recovery.



WALK THE ROUTE → SETTLE + SEE THE CUE

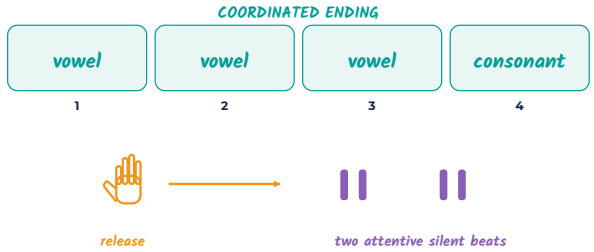
A USABLE ROUTE



SOUNDCHECK

FINAL RELEASE — Finish together
→ **QUIET PAGE CHANGE** — Find the next page
→ **STARTING NOTE** — Listen quietly
→ **NEW CUE** — Wait for preparation

TRANSITIONS



CLEAR ENDINGS

Illustrated methods you can understand, try, and use in real music.

STAGE GUIDE 01

Start with a workable performance brief

Stage-Ready Choir

Practical performance preparation / Use with your real event and rehearsal space

A useful performance plan begins with the actual event, not an ideal concert.

WHEN + WHERE

Arrival + soundcheck

WHO + ACCESS

People + practical needs

TWO PRIORITIES

Musical + practical

Before you begin

A useful performance plan begins with the actual event, not an ideal concert. Write down the decisions that affect repertoire, people, timing, and access before rehearsing the running order.

Confirm with the organizer

Record the date, arrival time, soundcheck window, performance length, venue contact, and who can approve changes. Ask whether the event includes spoken introductions, prayer, awards, or other items between songs.

Know the practical limits

Confirm the available standing or seated space, accessible route, audience position, microphones, accompaniment, lighting, and music stands. Check whether singers need permission to enter the venue early.

Decide what success means

Choose one musical aim and one practical aim. Example: clear text in the central song, and a calm transition into the final item. Use these aims to prioritize the next rehearsal.

YOUR EVENT CHECK

- [ ] Event contact and arrival time confirmed
- [ ] Actual performance duration recorded
- [ ] Access and equipment needs discussed
- [ ] One musical and one practical priority written

STAGE GUIDE 02

Choose repertoire the choir can deliver

Stage-Ready Choir

Practical performance preparation / Use with your real event and rehearsal space

The strongest programme is one the group can perform comfortably, clearly, and reliably.

READY

REPAIR ONE THING

NOT FOR THIS EVENT

Before you begin

The strongest programme is one the group can perform comfortably, clearly, and reliably. Familiarity, text, range, stamina, and preparation time matter more than the number of difficult pieces.

Use a readiness check

For each candidate song, assess starting notes, rhythm, text clarity, range comfort, memory expectations, and accompaniment. Mark each as ready, needs a specific repair, or not ready for this event.

Build contrast with purpose

Vary pace, mood, and texture while preserving a sensible vocal workload. Avoid placing several demanding pieces consecutively. Choose an opening the choir can enter confidently and a final item with a dependable ending.

Respect the music's permissions

Check that scores, arrangements, projected lyrics, accompaniment tracks, and any recording or streaming are licensed or otherwise permitted for the intended use. Owning a copy does not automatically permit every use.

YOUR EVENT CHECK

- ☐ *Each song has a clear readiness status*
- ☐ *Text and event context are suitable*
- ☐ *Demanding passages are not clustered unnecessarily*
- ☐ *Required permissions have been checked*

STAGE GUIDE 03

Create an honest running order

Stage-Ready Choir

Practical performance preparation / Use with your real event and rehearsal space

Time the whole sequence, including movement, introductions, applause, page changes, and starting notes.

9:40 planned + 0:20 margin = 10:00



Transitions and applause count as real time.

Before you begin

Time the whole sequence, including movement, introductions, applause, page changes, and starting notes. A list of song lengths alone underestimates the event.

Write a usable cue sheet

Use columns for item, duration, leader, starting pitch or accompaniment cue, equipment, and transition. Give every spoken introduction a maximum length and an owner.

Worked ten-minute example

Arrival and settle: 0:30. Introduction: 0:20. Song A: 2:20. Applause and reset: 0:25. Song B: 2:40. Short introduction: 0:20. Song C: 2:35. Final acknowledgement: 0:30. Planned total: 9:40, leaving twenty seconds of margin.

Test the transitions

Practise the final phrase of one item directly into the preparation for the next. Decide whether the choir remains still, changes formation, turns pages, or sits. Give each change enough time.

YOUR EVENT CHECK

- ☐ *All items have an owner*
- ☐ *Transitions are included in the timing*
- ☐ *The actual total fits the allotted slot*
- ☐ *There is a small practical timing margin*

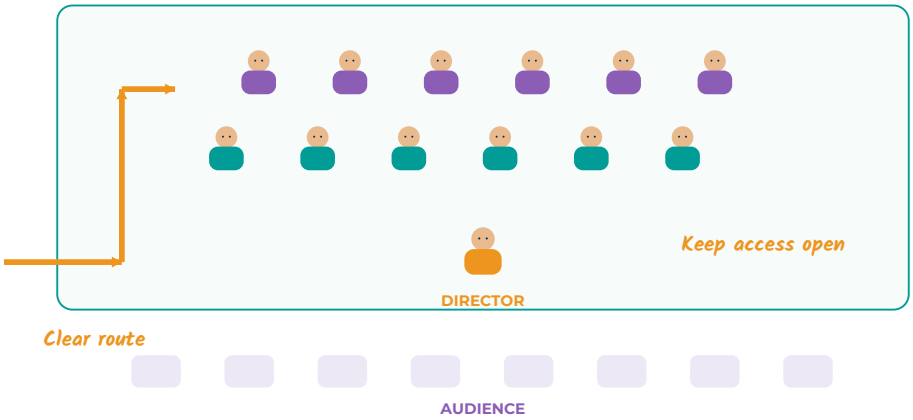
STAGE GUIDE 04

Plan a formation that people can use

Stage-Ready Choir

Practical performance preparation / Use with your real event and rehearsal space

A formation must support hearing, sightlines, access, and comfort.



Before you begin

A formation must support hearing, sightlines, access, and comfort. A visually neat arrangement is not useful if singers cannot see the director or safely reach their places.

Map the room

Sketch the audience, director, choir rows, accompaniment, microphone stands, doors, and cables. Mark accessible routes and any steps or risers that require special care.

Check from each position

Ask singers whether they can see the preparation and release gestures. Stagger rows where useful. Check seated singers and anyone using mobility aids before finalizing positions.

Test sound, then adjust

Sing one representative phrase at normal volume. Move positions only when there is a clear reason, such as blocked sightlines or an inaudible part. Keep changes simple enough to remember.

YOUR EVENT CHECK

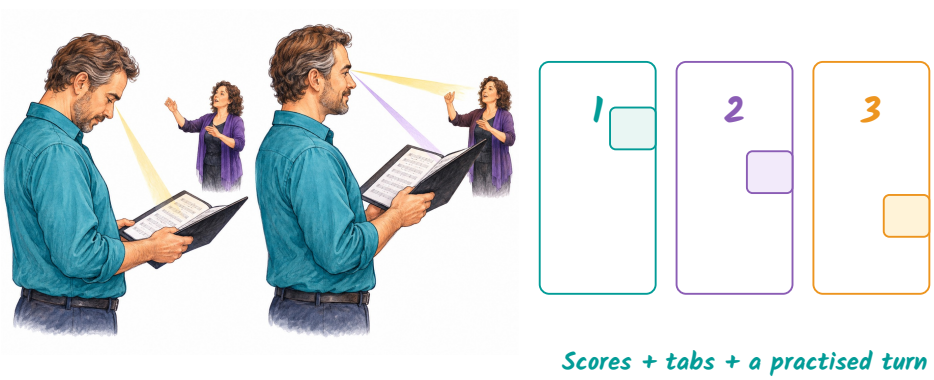
- [ ] Every singer has a clear sightline
- [ ] Entry and exit routes remain unobstructed
- [ ] Seats and mobility needs are included
- [ ] The formation has been tested with actual sound

Prepare scores and page turns

Stage-Ready Choir

Practical performance preparation / Use with your real event and rehearsal space

Folders and scores are part of the performance setup.



Scores + tabs + a practised turn

Before you begin

Folders and scores are part of the performance setup. Rehearse using the materials the choir will actually hold, including any large-print or accessible versions.

Make the order unmistakable

Place scores in running order and label each clearly. Mark cuts, repeats, breath points, starting words, and page turns using the choir's agreed symbols. Remove obsolete annotations that create conflicting instructions.

Rehearse the difficult turn

Locate the last safe place to turn before an entrance. Practise the turn silently, then connect the words before and after it. Use a stand or a different copy arrangement if holding the folder causes discomfort.

Keep a backup

The leader should have the final running order, spare authorized copies where permitted, accompaniment details, and emergency contacts. Avoid making a phone battery the only way to access essential information.

YOUR EVENT CHECK

- ☐ Scores match the final programme order
- ☐ Cuts and repeats agree across copies
- ☐ Difficult page turns have been practised
- ☐ Accessible materials and a practical backup exist

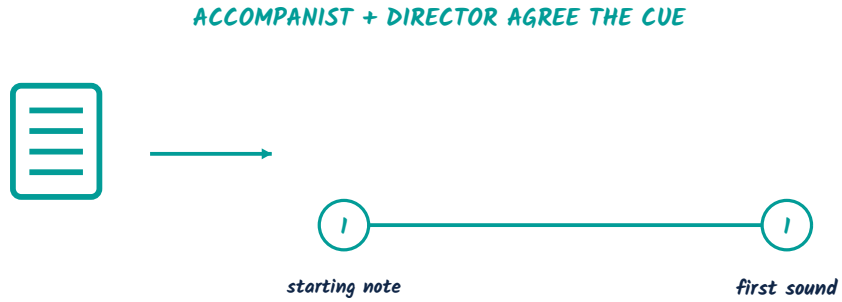
STAGE GUIDE 06

Coordinate accompaniment and starting pitches

Stage-Ready Choir

Practical performance preparation / Use with your real event and rehearsal space

The choir, director, and accompanist need the same version of every decision.



Before you begin

The choir, director, and accompanist need the same version of every decision. Agree the details early enough to rehearse them, especially introductions, repeats, tempo changes, and endings.

Confirm the version

Check key, arrangement, cuts, repeats, introductions, interludes, final chords, and any spoken lead-in. Mark who gives the first cue and who follows whom at each change.

Establish the first sound

Decide how each starting note will be given: instrument, pitch source, or confident model. Let the choir hear it before the preparation gesture. Do not ask singers to hold their breath during a long wait.

Practise a restart protocol

Choose a simple way to stop in rehearsal, identify a bar, hear the new starting notes, and begin again. During performance, use planned re-entry landmarks instead of restarting by habit.

YOUR EVENT CHECK

- [ ] All performers use the same key and cuts
- [ ] Opening and final cues are agreed
- [ ] Starting pitches have a clear source
- [ ] At least two internal re-entry landmarks are known

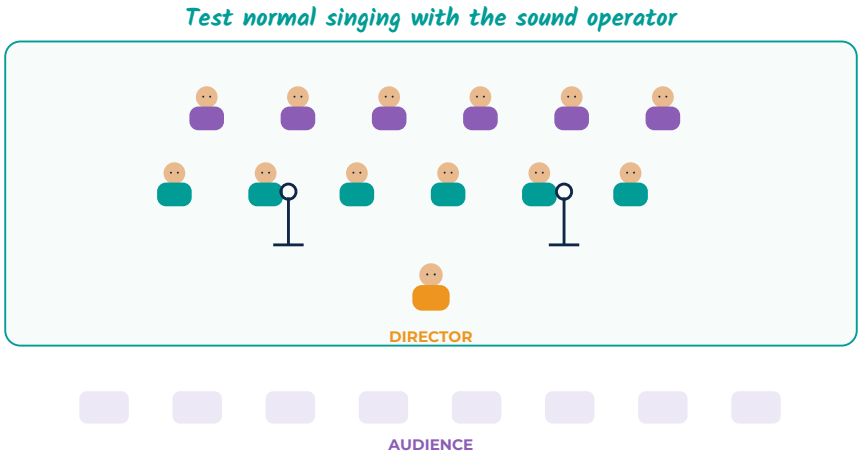
STAGE GUIDE 07

Use soundcheck for decisions, not a full rehearsal

Stage-Ready Choir

Practical performance preparation / Use with your real event and rehearsal space

A short, representative soundcheck is more useful than singing the whole programme repeatedly.



Before you begin

A short, representative soundcheck is more useful than singing the whole programme repeatedly. Work with the venue's sound operator and preserve a normal, comfortable singing level.

Choose a revealing excerpt

Include a clear text line, a fuller moment, and any exposed quiet passage. Tell the operator which parts need to remain audible. Use the actual choir formation and accompaniment.

Change the setup first

If clarity is poor, check microphone placement, monitor level, accompaniment balance, and sightlines with the operator. Avoid solving every sound problem by asking singers to sing louder.

Record the final arrangement

Note which stands, channels, positions, and cues are used. Keep cables out of walking routes. Do not move or adjust unfamiliar equipment without permission.

YOUR EVENT CHECK

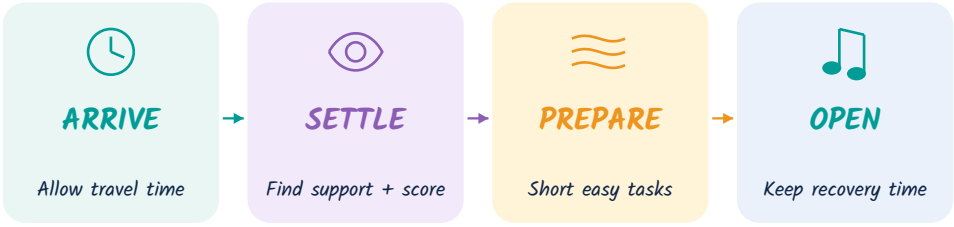
- ☐ *A representative excerpt is selected*
- ☐ *Normal vocal effort is maintained*
- ☐ *Operator and director agree the final setup*
- ☐ *Cables and microphone positions are safe*

Warm up for the task ahead

Stage-Ready Choir

Practical performance preparation / Use with your real event and rehearsal space

Choose a familiar preparation that fits the event, the time available, and how the singers feel that day.



Before you begin

Choose a familiar preparation that fits the event, the time available, and how the singers feel that day. More warm-up is not automatically better, especially before a demanding programme.

Prepare in a sensible order

Settle body and attention, use an ordinary breath-and-speech task, introduce a gentle middle-range sound, then rehearse one feature that appears in the programme. Include recovery between repetitions.

Keep effort comfortable

Offer a different octave, a smaller pattern, or listening instead of singing when appropriate. Avoid breath-holding contests and extreme range exploration. Stop a task that produces pain, dizziness, or vocal strain.

Finish with a relevant transfer

Test one opening and one ending rather than running every song. Allow quiet recovery before going on. A singer who is hoarse or unwell should not be pushed to sing through it.

YOUR EVENT CHECK

- ☐ *The routine suits today's repertoire*
- ☐ *Comfortable alternatives are available*
- ☐ *Recovery time is built into the routine*
- ☐ *The choir is prepared rather than fatigued*

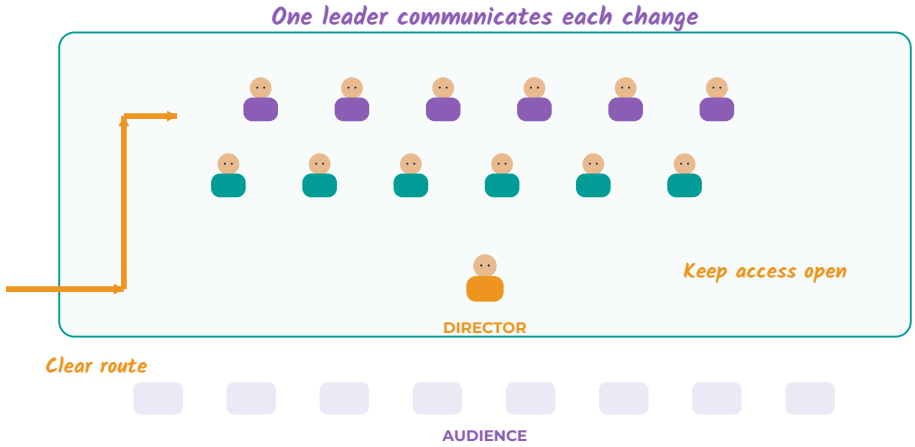
STAGE GUIDE 09

Make arrival and backstage instructions clear

Stage-Ready Choir

Practical performance preparation / Use with your real event and rehearsal space

Send one concise set of instructions and confirm that people can access it.



Before you begin

Send one concise set of instructions and confirm that people can access it. Repeated messages with changing details are harder to follow than a dated final plan.

What to communicate

Give the venue address, arrival point, time, contact person, clothing guidance, music requirements, water and break arrangements, and the expected finish time. Include an accessible route and any necessary transport information.

What to check on arrival

Use a simple attendance list, confirm positions, locate facilities, and tell the choir when to be ready for soundcheck. Have a quiet way for someone to report a practical or wellbeing concern.

What to avoid

Do not block corridors, change the order informally, or allow competing instructions from several leaders. If a change is necessary, one nominated person communicates it clearly to everyone affected.

YOUR EVENT CHECK

- [ ] A dated final arrival plan has been shared
- [ ] One person owns last-minute updates
- [ ] Attendance and practical concerns can be checked
- [ ] The choir knows where and when to wait

STAGE GUIDE 10

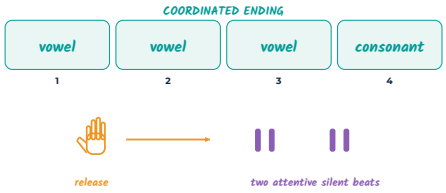
Rehearse the first and last ten seconds

Stage-Ready Choir

Practical performance preparation / Use with your real event and rehearsal space

Openings and endings carry a lot of practical information.





Before you begin

Openings and endings carry a lot of practical information. They deserve focused rehearsal even when the middle of the piece is musically secure.

Opening sequence

Practise arrival at the ready position, eye contact, starting pitch, the director's preparation, and the first sound. Include an audience-like pause so singers learn to wait rather than anticipate.

Ending sequence

Agree the final vowel, consonant, release, and short moment of attention afterwards. The director then acknowledges the audience or gives the next transition. Comfortable stillness is enough; no one needs to freeze or hold their breath.

Test without reminders

Run the sequence once with spoken support and once without. If it breaks down, repair the precise cue or transition rather than repeating the complete song.

YOUR EVENT CHECK

- ☐ *The opening works after an unpredictable pause*
- ☐ *The first vowel is coordinated*
- ☐ *The final consonant and release are aligned*
- ☐ *The next movement waits for the agreed cue*

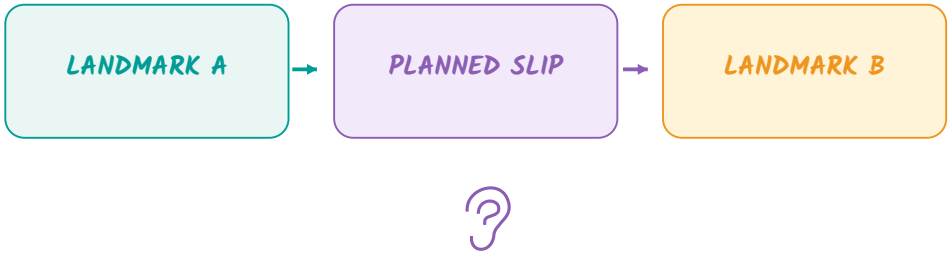
STAGE GUIDE II

Recover calmly when something changes

Stage-Ready Choir

Practical performance preparation / Use with your real event and rehearsal space

> **A recovery plan gives the choir useful options.**



Before you begin

A recovery plan gives the choir useful options. It is more practical than promising a mistake-free performance or telling people simply to be confident.

Missed entry or lost place

Listen, find the director, and rejoin at the next agreed landmark. Confirm the landmark's words and starting notes during rehearsal. Do not ask singers to scramble through pages while continuing uncertainly.

Practical interruption

If accompaniment or equipment fails, the director decides whether to continue, pause, or restart. The choir follows the visible stop or ready signal rather than several people giving instructions.

Someone needs to leave

Agree an unobstructed route and a responsible contact. Maintain the singer's privacy and do not insist that anyone remain on stage while unwell or uncomfortable.

YOUR EVENT CHECK

- [ ] *Re-entry landmarks are marked*
- [ ] *Stop and ready signals are familiar*
- [ ] *One leader makes sequence decisions*
- [ ] *A practical exit and support contact are known*

Give feedback that improves the next performance

Stage-Ready Choir

Practical performance preparation / Use with your real event and rehearsal space

Debrief the event after a suitable pause.



Before you begin

Debrief the event after a suitable pause. Focus on what the choir can influence and separate a musical observation from a judgement about a person.

Start with evidence

Choose a concrete success, such as a coordinated opening after a long pause. Invite singers to describe what helped that success happen so it can be repeated.

Choose one next task

Locate one challenge by song, phrase, or transition. Decide whether the next action is musical practice, a clearer cue, an equipment change, or better instructions. Give the task an owner and a rehearsal date.

Close the loop

At the next meeting, test the planned change in context. Keep notes brief: what happened, what was changed, and whether it helped. Preserve useful habits instead of replacing everything after one difficult moment.

YOUR EVENT CHECK

- ☐ *One specific success is recorded*
- ☐ *One actionable challenge is selected*
- ☐ *The next task has an owner and time*
- ☐ *The change will be tested in a real run*

Your one-page event plan

Stage-Ready Choir

Complete before the final rehearsal / Share responsibilities with your team

Keep your programme, cues, arrangements, and next steps together.

DATE + VENUE

ARRIVAL / SOUNDCHECK / START

CONTACT + COMMUNICATION OWNER

PROGRAMME + CUES

1.
2.
3.
4.

SKETCH YOUR FORMATION + ROUTE

NEXT ACTION / OWNER / DEADLINE

RE-ENTRY LANDMARKS + BACKUP PLAN